

They are professional, poised, with better paydays than ever. Tabloid princesses and tiara stars, they also act in this summer's noisiest films.

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Bipasha Basu, having generated tabloid headlines for a posh new haircut, is getting ready to pack her bags for Rome where she will be playing one of three love interests in Siddharth Anand's untitled Yash Raj film opposite Ranbir Kapoor. It's a movie which Katrina Kaif was dropped from, because it was becoming too long. But you won't find Kaif moping over it. Enjoying a sweet comeback, with hits last year in *Namaste London*, *Apne*, *Partner* and *Welcome*, after being declared a disaster in her 2003 debut film, *Boom*, she says in her London-meets-Hawaii accent, "I would have been a bit lost in the film. We're all friends, all grown up and it's better to work on something more substantial." Which she is doing now, in another Yash Raj movie to be helmed by Kabir Khan, starring John Abraham, supposed rival of her boyfriend, Salman Khan.

It's a professionalism that is being rewarded with an unlikely pay cheque. Kaif, 24, who stars in Abbas Mustan's thriller, *Race*, as well as Anees Bazmee's comedy *Singh is Kinng* and Subhash Ghai's *Yuvraaj*, has just signed a two film future deal with Studio 18 for Rs 6 crore. Kareena Kapoor, 28, who, wowed everyone with *Jab We Met* last year, is already demanding and also getting Rs 3.5 crore per movie, with endless press releases from her publicity factory anointing her the Queen of Bollywood. Director Imtiaz Ali whose *Jab We Met* played a considerable role in the re-assertion of her box-office credentials, says: "I was so amazed by her no-fuss working style that one day when we were shooting, I told her, 'you've got to throw a tantrum or two to justify your reputation'."

Kapoor didn't. But she is certainly back in the A-list in an industry which is as much run on whim as it is on wind-fall, where women don't open movies but definitely enhance them—as Kapoor no doubt will do, as a woman on the run from Akshay Kumar's recovery agent, in

KAREENA KAPOOR, 28: She has signed two films for Rs 3.5 crore each

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